

A Brief History of Relativism

William Gairdner

As a rule, only very learned and clever men deny what is obviously true.

Common men have less brains, but more sense.

William T. Stace, Professor of History, Princeton (1952)

When asked where relativism comes from, most people are likely to shrug and say: "It's just the way things are." Some might add that Einstein started it all, or that anthropology shows how every culture has its own customs and truths, or that psychology has proven all values are "personal," and so on. And everyone has seen movies or read books that play with the idea that reality is not an objective thing but a composite of different "perspectives." Most of this is trotted out as commonly held truth and often dressed up as morally tolerant intellectual sophistication. But in the end, most people are getting at the same strictly modern idea: they think that *reality is subjective*, and thus dependent on your point of view and that this fact is as close as anyone can get to the truth.

But on closer inspection, we have to ask what people really mean when they say that things are relative. For there is quite a difference between that we can understand something best after relating it to something else and saying that because we must relate things, they can never be understood for what they are in themselves. I mean to say, there is a big difference between *relationism* and *relativism*.

RELATIONISM

The idea that we get at the truth by relating things has been around a long time. We contrast night and day, disease and health, oranges and apples, and so on. And there are experiences everyone has had that dramatically illustrate how what we know can be discovered only by its *relation* to something else.

For example, suppose you are sitting minding your own business on a train, in a car, or on an airplane when suddenly, you start to move. The trip is finally underway! Then, just as suddenly, you are overcome by a queasy sense of unreality. You are absolutely certain you are moving. But is it true? Could it be that you are perfectly motionless and that the vehicle beside you is moving? Which is it? And how can you know?

This familiar situation typically produces a feeling of radical uncertainty, a moment of panic during which we feel a desperate need to know what is *really* happening. We suddenly find ourselves searching furtively for something that *ought* to be stationary. The ground? The platform? A building? Something - anything - to test whether our feeling of motion is real or imaginary. The very instant we find a fixed point of reference, we feel immense relief as the logic of motion falls into place. But what a shock it is to discover that it is we who were at rest, while the vehicle beside us was moving, and how strange to have been so deeply betrayed by our own senses!

This is the feeling most people casually think of as "relativity." But it is a feeling that disappears quickly once they understand the objective *relation* between moving things and stationary things. For in reality, there is nothing *relative* about this situation. It is just that physical movement of any kind makes sense only as measured in relation to something else. Once we have our reference points, it is precisely measurable, predictable to an extraordinary degree of accuracy, and follows the same exacting - and absolute - laws everywhere in the universe.

Time is the same. It is told in relation to where you are on earth or in space, as anyone knows who has experienced jet lag. In the sense that we have figured out how to segment the unbroken flow of time into years, days, seconds, nanoseconds, and so on, it is also extremely precise and predictable. So much so that we can fire rockets into space that travel millions of miles at incredible speeds yet still predict exactly when and where they will be years later. Space and time together are the most typical ways we experience the need to relate things in order, say, to meet someone at a specific address, time, intersection, and so on. And such is the case for all things physical and temporal.¹

The most common nonphysical forms of relationism, however, are generally conceptual, moral, or cultural. For example, we are commonly told that good and evil, truth and justice, and many other such notions are "relative." However, this is often an illusion, too, just like the train we thought was moving when it wasn't. When we think of two people who vigorously disagree about the truth of what happened at the scene of a crime, for example, we often say their different perceptions are relative to what each saw. *But we never doubt there is a single truth lurking somewhere.* If someone later shows us a video of the actual event, we might conclude that they were both wrong or that one of them was lying, and everyone can now see the same indisputable truth. In the same fashion, as we shall see in the next chapter, people all over the world recognize general concepts of trust, equality, honesty, love, justice so on, even if they often differ sharply over specific instances and degrees of these things.

On a philosophical note, it is interesting to learn that the basic concept of "relation" is itself a universal. The philosopher Bertrand Russell (1872-1970) was a model of clear thinking and writing (I believe these go together) for all philosophers, and in his justly admired little book *The Problems of Philosophy*,² he used several chapters to describe the world of universals - what they are and how we know they exist. For Russell, most of the concepts of common language are themselves universals. For example, the words "cat" or "run" or "cut" are universal concepts and become particular only when we think of or engage in a particular act or observation (we see or imagine a certain real cat, we run to the store, or we cut a loaf of bread). But more to the point at hand, Russell expands on the fact that the basic concept of relations is itself universal. For example, the proposition "two and two are four" states a relation of quantity between the universal "two" and the universal "four," and just as for the spatial relation involved in saying Toronto is "north of" New York, such relations are true, absolute, and universal. And, he maintains, relations such as "north of" something, or "two and two are four," as well as relations of time, such as "before" and "after," will always be so whether anyone exists to know it or not.

RELATIVISM

Relativism, however, is a far more disorienting concept than relationism, and in the next chapter I will outline some varieties. But for now we need keep in mind only that in its modern radical form, relativism means not only that we must relate things but moreover, that *there is no ultimate truth possible*

¹ There is, however, a continuing and fascinating debate today between so-called "substantialists" and "relationists" on the matter of space and time. The former say that space and time exist in their own right without regard to the existence or non-existence of things. The latter deny this. They say that we can know space and time only because of the existence of things and that it is in terms of their relations that we are able to describe both. That is the point I have made here also, primarily because I cannot imagine what space or time could be without things. For example, without things, how could we possibly know there was space since there would be nothing in that space to perceive? How could complete emptiness be a thing? In AD 379 Saint Augustine addressed this interesting question in his Confessions, where he made the argument that before God created matter there was no time, only eternity, which is timeless. It exists as an eternal present. But once things came into existence, time began as something measurable. Even though there is still an eternal present, things now ceaselessly flow from it both into the past and into the anticipated future.

² Bertrand Russell, *The Problems of Philosophy* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, Home University Library, 1959 and 1972).

because there is no fixed, or permanent, or privileged foundation outside our own perceptions or beliefs or culture from which to judge anything as more "true" than anything else. In a later chapter we will see that some clever thinkers proudly style themselves "postmodernists" or "anti-foundationalists" on this basis. They do not say there is no truth. They say there is a multiplicity of truths – perhaps an infinity of them – any one of which is as "true" as any other. Now, as anyone can see, this statement makes a mockery of the basic idea of truth, which is a concept we use to decide between competing reality claims, especially between true and false ones. And of course, if there is no foundation from which to truly know anything, then the view that there is no truth cannot be known either. At any rate, whenever we choose to ignore the fact that basic distinctions between what is true and false are always possible, relativism quickly turns into an intellectual snake that swallows its own tail. Unfortunately, a lot of modern academics and social scientists have been all too uncritical of the self-devouring tendencies of relativism to notice its corrosive effect on their own disciplines.

Most human beings, however, instinctively understand the need for action based on some kind of logical or moral precision, so they find the suggestion that there can never be certain truth very disturbing, if not obviously wrong. This is especially problematic for parents striving to raise good children. So why, despite this, do so many embrace relativism? One answer is that people live double lives. They are relativists in public but certainly not in private, nor with friends or family. We will speak more of this modern split personality later. Regardless of the motive, however, it is clear that relativism, especially in its moral and cultural form, has swiftly become our public philosophy. But it did not simply materialize from thin air. So we need to ask where it came from.

ANCIENT ROOTS

Some say relativism is very old, quoting the ancient Greek thinker Protagoras. He was a Sophist famous for the line "Man is the measure of all things." But in Plato's critique we find him quoted in more detail: "As each thing appears to me, so it is for me, and as it appears to you, so it is for you."³ Protagoras went on to insist that for this reason there is no such thing as falsehood or truth, overlooking that such a claim meant his own views were meaningless. His famous quotation is more or less what we hear from the ordinary relativist at a modern cocktail party. However, whether this was something we ought to call relativism in the modern sense remains under debate.⁴ But the historical pattern is clear. The ancient world

³ Plato, *Theaetetus*, in John M. Cooper and D.S. Hutchinson, eds, *Plato: Complete Works* (Indianapolis, IN: Hackett, 1997), 169.

⁴ Some historians have said that Protagoras did not mean that all things are relative. Rather, he meant that Man (humankind), not nature, is the primary object of human study. And so his was a doctrine of humanism, not of relativism. On this point, see the entry for "Relativity of Knowledge" in *The Encyclopaedia Britannica*, 11th ed., vol. 23. However, Plato cites the full argument by Protagoras, which is clearly relativist.

But there is a historical pattern here of some interest. Protagoras (485-410 BC) lived under Greek paganism, which, with its many warring and fickle gods, had diluted ancient Greek belief in absolutes. For along with many other Sophists of his time (Sophists were the first Greek philosophers to accept payment for teaching, and they took relish in winning logical debates without regard to truth or the good), Protagoras had become enamoured of Heraclitus's view that all things are in flux. But once having accepted the idea that nothing is fixed, he was then forced to argue that all sensations must therefore be subjective and that reality can thus never be known for certain. This ancient form of relativism led to a swift breakdown of Greek philosophy that was not reversed until the time of Plato and Aristotle, who, each in his own way, restored concepts of the absolute to philosophy in a manner that has framed Western civilization for almost two thousand years. Indeed, modern relativism is really a kind of counterattack on the absolutist and "essentialist" ideas of Plato and Aristotle as they have come down to us in European thought. (In later chapters we will come to grips with Nietzsche, Heidegger, and their French acolytes Michel Foucault and Jacques Derrida, all of whom were anti-Platonists.)

experienced a kind of philosophical relativism that lasted barely a century and then evaporated under the withering criticisms first of Plato and then of his student Aristotle, two of the greatest philosophers who ever lived. It next raised its doubting and disruptive head during the sixteenth-century Renaissance and railed with a vengeance through the so-called Age of Reason, which lasted unroughly the end of the eighteenth century. Still, although it is true a number of ancient thinkers were relativists of a sort, they were never quite like us. For even if certain of them denied the possibility of *knowing* reality absolutely, they did not necessarily deny that an absolute reality might actually exist beyond their ken. And certainly no entire civilization before our own ever publicly conceived of the whole cosmos as an utterly alien and meaningless accident, as do many moderns.⁵

The various logical and moral crises that inevitably arise from a belief in relativism will be exposed fully in the chapters to come. For now, let us look briefly at its more recent origins in the hope of understanding why an entire civilization - our own - has so confidently shifted over the last few centuries from an understanding of the world in which everyone had confidence to one that dismisses the very idea that any such confidence is possible.

THE ROOTS OF MODERN RELATIVISM

The Rise of Science

During the Middle Ages, from about AD 1000 to 1500, social and moral authority were generally rooted in religious belief. During the transition to the modern period, however, we begin to see appeals to the worldly authority of reason and science, both of which were increasingly relied upon to examine reality *objectively*, which is to say, without the filters of inherited social or religious values or personal subjectivity.

So firmly entrenched is this view by now that modern scientists regard this method as the only route to truth and themselves as defenders of objectivity against superstition and moral oppression (even

From thence forward, the Greek preoccupation with philosophical absolutes and universals was so influential that it was eventually merged with the Judeo-Christian teachings about revelation, the existence of a single absolute God, and a single moral authority. It was Saint Augustine's City of God (early fifth century AD) that first successfully incorporated Platonic philosophy within Christianity in a synthesis that was to last over 600 years. By the thirteenth century, however, Aristotle's teachings were replacing those of Plato, and another great thinker, Saint Thomas Aquinas, set to work incorporating them into Christian theology via his magisterial *Summa Theologiae*. This second synthesis remains in force today as the official theology of the Roman Catholic Church, despite the fact that we are clearly living in another age of public skepticism and relativism. My point is that once any civilization abandons belief in some absolute principle of reality that has provided it with the conviction that the cosmos has a purpose, relativism soon fills the vacuum, regardless of the historical period. We await our modern equivalent of Plato and Aristotle.

⁵ A recent version of this notion was bleakly articulated by Professor William Provine, of Cornell University, in a small circulation Canadian newsletter (U-Turn, no. 4, Winter 1997). He was confident enough about the insignificance of the universe to say: "let me summarize my views loud and clear. There are no gods, no purposes, and no goal-directed forces of any kind. There is no life after death . . . no foundation for ethics, no ultimate meaning in life." Provine doesn't seem to realize that if he were to take himself at his own word, he could not give a convincing reason why he gets out of bed in the morning, why he is motivated to learn or teach anything, or why he should be upset if someone steals his car, for in a truly meaningless world there can be no ultimate defence of our actions nor any objection to the actions of others.

* Some extreme relativists today, such as Paul Feyerabend - see, for example, *Against Method* (London: New Left Books, 1973) - say that this is not possible, that even the most "objective" modern science is in fact a product of underlying assumptions, of the choices we make to observe things in certain ways and not others, of what we include and exclude in even the most "objective" theories and methods of observation. To such extreme relativists, even things such as mathematical certainty and the existence of the neutron are but human inventions. Many postmodernists claim that "the world of things is a creation of the world of words." This, and similar attitudes, will be taken up later in some detail.

though the modern idea that reason and science have always been at war with religion is in fact quite recent).⁶ While we have accepted the objective findings of science as superior and now rely on these for our truth, we have just as wholeheartedly - even, I would say, dogmatically separated them from any religious or higher meaning. Religious explanations of reality are now everywhere considered matters of private subjective faith that have little to do with the objective world. The typical modern scientist simply assumes that the laws and forces of our extraordinarily complex natural world have arisen spontaneously, due to some inherent, if inexplicable, characteristic of matter. But the modern inquiry stops abruptly there. We generally make no public effort to ask where the laws and forces (the many "constants of nature" governing all matter) have themselves come from. This reminds us of the Hindu who, when asked to explain what holds up the world, explained that it rests on the back of a turtle.

"And the turtle?"

"Well, he rests on another turtle."

"And this turtle?"

"From there," he said with a smile, "it's turtles, all the way down."

Now, any thinking person might well ask: Why have so many modern scientists, many of whom are deeply spiritual people, divorced reason from spirit? The most likely answer is that scientific rationalists felt it was impossible to be objective without first rejecting everything subjective, so to achieve objectivity they had to dismiss all nonmaterial, abstract, spiritual, and conceptual solutions. This further opened the door to radical skepticism and doubt.

Reorganizing the Mind

A very early step in this direction was taken by William of Occam, an English thinker of the late Middle Ages (1300?-1349). He was fed up with the interminable abstract debates between scholars trying to prove how many angels could dance on the head of a pin. In the preceding centuries, the dominant philosophers had been convinced that ideas, forms, and universals were the most real of all things and that matter was but a degraded instance of those ideas and forms. The perfect triangle, for example, is described by an abstract geometric formula that tells us precisely what a triangle is. But only imperfect triangles made of pencil lines, wood, or metal can be found in the physical world. The idea of a perfect triangle is by definition prior to, and more *real* than, any imperfect, physical triangle. Opposing philosophers, however, were gaining ascendancy, and Occam tipped the balance. He argued that only particular physical experiences are real. Generalities, universals - indeed, all abstract ideas - are just *names* that have no real existence. They exist only in our minds. This philosophy was later called "nominalism" (from the Latin *nomen*, for "name"). And names, he argued, are but abstractions, mere fluff. Smoke and mirrors. It was a philosophy that fitted perfectly the growing scientific preference for only measurable physical, testable results.

Another influential step was taken much later by Descartes (he died in 1650), who famously made radical doubt the cornerstone of his philosophy. He claimed that since our senses, as well as bad

⁶ Indeed, the word "science" is rooted in the Latin word for knowledge, and there is no small irony in the fact that just as men such as Galileo and Newton believed their "objective" and "scientific" discoveries were unveiling the natural laws of God, so did their religious accusers and detractors consider themselves to be "scientists" of the highest order. This was so because theology, which was the only discipline that strived to integrate all other forms of knowledge within a higher truth, was widely considered the "Queen of Sciences." In the minds of most serious thinkers, The Book of Nature and the Book of God were considered to be different manifestations of the same truth, and this was the generally accepted view from the Middle Ages until about the middle of the nineteenth century. Indeed, there are still many excellent scientists who feel this way. But it is certainly not the general view any longer.

arguments, may easily deceive us, the only way to find certain truth is to begin by doubting everything except the existence of our own doubting minds. After thus establishing our own existence, we may then move on by logical steps to establish other certainties. With his famous pronouncement "I think, therefore I am,"⁷ Descartes opened wide the doors to the specifically modern belief that (contrary to what the best minds had always been saying) *each of us can individually arrive at the truth, and this capacity is equal in all men*. It was then to be only a matter of time before a claim to know *the* truth became a personal claim to *my* truth.⁸

Now, I do not think that people have anything like an equal capacity to distinguish the true from the false. If anything, social science tells us the opposite. The majority of us are most often dupes of appearances, wishful thinking, inadequate facts, and pseudo arguments.⁹ Nevertheless, here was a flattering idea that made Descartes very popular, for even though he was himself a God-fearing man, his new philosophy, by relocating truth within the thinking individual, had the effect of undermining the intellectual and moral prestige and therefore the control available to secular and religious authorities.

Reorganizing the World

As if this emerging recourse to strict mental reasoning were not enough, the newly objective science was quick to give a demonstration of how thoroughly our senses (and the authorities) can deceive us. Galileo dropped the first of many intellectual bombs. He stunned the thinking world by confirming that the sun does not travel around the earth, as ordinary perceptions still suggest, but rather the reverse: the earth is just one of many planets circling the sun. Here was *relationism* with a vengeance, and it upset a worldview thousands of years old: the venerable

Judeo-Christian view that God had created the earth for human beings and set it as a jewel in heaven to be lit with the sun by day and the moon by night. In expressly denying this comforting Genesis account, science now seemed to be attacking God himself! As a devout Catholic, however, Galileo had tried desperately to save the church from denying his findings and thus from its own self-embarrassment. But it was too late, and the Galileo incident is today considered an important early example of science winning the first of many battles in a war against religious prejudice, even though this is not quite the historical truth.*

⁷ If we start from a faith in materialism and doubt, we indeed may say "I think, therefore I am." However, if we start from a faith in God, we may reverse this and say, "I am, therefore I think." Neither of these faiths can be indubitably proven by science or logic.

⁸ In his opening words of his *Discourse on Method* (1637), we see the hint of three emerging modern themes: *objective science* (of which mathematics was the new queen), *individualism*, and modern *egalitarianism*. Before Descartes, it was a common assumption that people differed so strongly in their opinions because some were clearly better thinkers or simply far better people than others. But to the astonishment of all, Descartes starts out by claiming that "Good sense is the most evenly shared thing in the world," so much so that we never hear anyone say they need more of it! As everyone feels way, he goes on, it is therefore unlikely we are all mistaken, *and so it must be true*, and therefore - just look where this "objective" thinker takes his conclusion: "the capacity to judge correctly and to distinguish the true from false, which is properly what one calls common sense or reason, is naturally equal in all men." See Rene Descartes, *Discourse on Method and the Meditations*, trans. F.E. Sutcliffe (New York: Penguin, 1968), 27ff. I am indebted to Etienne Gilson, *The Unity of Philosophical Experience* (New York: Charles Scribner, 1937), for his penetrating critique of Descartes and his philosophy.

⁹ On the question of pandemic public ignorance, see, for example, the journal *Critical Review* 14, nos 2-3 (Summer 2000). This same journal published yet another collection of papers on the same topic, vol. 18, nos 1-3 Summer 2006).

*The irony of this misconception bears mention, namely that modern science arose only in the Christian West. It died a whimpering death in the Greek world and also among the Romans and the Chinese. And there is a reason. As Catholic philosopher Stanley J. Jaki has argued - see "Science: Western or What?" in *Patterns or Principles* (Bryn Mawr, PA: Intercollegiate Studies Institute, 1995), 161-78 - modern science would not have been possible without our belief that there is

Isaac Newton was born the year that Galileo died, and at the tender age of twenty-six he dropped his own Big Bertha. His *Principia* (1687) was a work that would change perceptions of the universe forever. It is one of the most astonishing works of scientific thinking ever created, and in the public mind (although certainly not in Newton's own mind) it finished off the Aristotelian and Christian belief that the cosmos is a natural, organic order, a home of which we are the centre and purpose. The universe Newton described is ours. We think of it as "mechanical in the sense that like a clock it is self-sustaining. There is order everywhere . . . Physical processes take place within an unchanging vault of absolute space and in accord with the unchanging beat of absolute time. Propelling itself through space, the universal force of gravitation subordinates all material objects to a single modality of attraction. And all this proceeds in accordance with simple mathematical laws."¹⁰

Ironically, although his extraordinary work seemed to confirm so much of the rationalist rebellion against the idea of a purposeful cosmos, Newton was a religious mystic and alchemist who never once doubted that "this most beautiful system of the sun, planets and comets, could only proceed from the counsel and domination of an intelligent and powerful Being."¹¹ He has also been charged with reintroducing mysticism to Western science because he so convincingly proved that the reality we know is controlled by universal laws that are invisible and operate "at a distance" (such as the moon pulling the oceans and forming the tides). In a later chapter on physics we will see that quantum physics continues this quasi-mystical bent in the purest of the physical sciences.

Western civilization has followed Newton's physics for more than three hundred years, and despite modifications by later physicists that have more to do with deep space, unimaginable speeds, and the origins of the universe than with what happens here on earth, we will always live under his laws. But we have utterly rejected his theological reasoning for their existence.¹² Newton himself, however, was smart enough to see that figuring out how a law works does not explain its reason for being or its cause. He knew above all that science is silent as to the causes and ultimate purposes of life.

But as mentioned, after centuries of intricate but philosophically barren rationalism, many modern cosmologists and philosophers seeking ultimate causes and purposes are once again leaning toward Newton's view that the universe may be the product of intelligent design. Others deny this, arguing that the universe designs itself. At any rate this *designer vs. self-designed* dispute is at the watershed of modern scientific opinion on the origins of the universe and the forms of life. Some highly respected physicists and mathematicians go much further. They are persuaded that *the entire cosmos came into existence so that human consciousness would eventually arise to observe it!* We may have gotten bumped from the centre of our own solar system over recent centuries, but such new and fascinating modern views argue that we

an absolute physical reality separate from ourselves characterized by order and law, the truth of which may be discovered. All scientists today continue to hold this belief, even if they gag a little when they have to acknowledge its theological source. Nevertheless, it is this foundational belief that underlies the secondary belief in "objectivity," and it is this same objectivity that for the past few centuries has been turned against the religious assumptions that spawned it.

¹⁰ David Berlinski, *Newton's Gift: How Sir Isaac Newton Unlocked the System World* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 2000), xiv. This is an intriguing accessible account of Newton's life, work, and significance.

¹¹ *Ibid.*, 172.

¹² For that matter, the religious beliefs of all three of our greatest scientists, Galileo, Newton, and Einstein, have simply been ignored. Although in minds science and theology were indelibly connected, in the public mind became increasingly disconnected, despite the fact that the mysteries they revealed were no less mysterious for having been formulated as laws and universals. Newton, for example, was fully aware that although his law explained the first time in history how gravity works, and although he formulated it as absolute, or constant, of nature, the law does not tell us what gravity is. No has ever told us what gravity is, simply because no one knows. (Newton's law specifies that the attraction between physical bodies is proportional to mass and inversely proportional to the square of the distance between them.)

belong right back at the centre again. But this time, they mean . . . at the centre of the entire universe! We will return to this intriguing idea.

For the moment, we need only see that despite deep convictions about cosmic purpose felt by many modern scientists, the general direction of today's scientific community and, therefore, of the public mind - and certainly of public education, which we must assume to reflect that mind - has run strongly against this idea. We increasingly describe ourselves in defiantly *materialist*, *atheistic*, and therefore, *relativistic* terms, and these three concepts form the underpinning of our thoroughly modern orthodoxy. The bleakness of this view could hardly be better expressed than by Harvard astronomer Margaret Geller, who asks: "Why should the universe have a point? What point? It's just a physical system, what point is there?"¹³ Let us not miss the connection between this view of physics and our topic: when there is no point to anything, relativism rules.

Science and the Relativity of Morals

For a stark example of how this newly *objective* thinking led at once to the first detailed *subjective* theory of moral relativism, we could do no better than to turn to the work of Thomas Hobbes (1588-1679).¹⁴ His discovery of the mechanical work of Galileo so filled him with intellectual energy that he immediately set about building a new theory of politics around the idea of individuals and their societies as *machines in motion*. Every human life can be explained as the action of a mechanical apparatus comprised of sense organs, nerves, muscles, bones, and so on, kept in motion by its own natural impulse to satisfy appetites and avoid pain - the greatest pain of all being death. In defiance of all religious opinion to the effect that morality is rooted in a higher moral law, Hobbes simply declared that whatever is the object of any man's appetite or desire he calls "Good," and whatever is the object of his hate and aversion he calls "Evil." And what was the warrant for the use of these words? There is none, he declared, "For these words of Good, and Evil . . . are ever used with relation to the person that useth them: there being nothing simply and absolutely so; nor any common rule of Good and Evil."¹⁵

Mechanical solutions to the problem of morality have been proposed repeatedly ever since, perhaps with greatest effect in the nineteenth century by Jeremy Bentham and the young John Stuart Mill. Once joined with the rising popularity of democracy, their utilitarian formula for how to make "moral" decisions without any reference to God or any other universal or absolute became "the greatest good of the greatest number." Mill surrendered this relativism once he saw that majorities may happily choose very evil things. Nevertheless, the simplistic idea that truth may be decided simply by voting democratically was by then firmly established.

The Run-Up to Modern Relativism

Public confidence that clear reasoning would always somehow point the way to freedom and truth had begun to weaken long before this period - at least by the end of the eighteenth century. There were

¹³ Margaret Geller, via Jeffrey Satinover, *The Quantum Brain* (New York : John Wiley and Sons, 2001), 4, quoted in S. Weinberg, *Dreams of a Final Theory* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1992), 225.

¹⁴ Hobbes was a close friend and supporter of Sir Francis Bacon (1561-1626) and was deeply influenced by Bacon's "objective" methods of scientific observation. Bacon vehemently disliked all religious authority and sought to cleanse the observing mind of all contaminating bias in order to observe The Book of Nature as he was sure it must be in its objectively pure state. He was the first of many Western scientists to replace the omnipotence of God with the omnipotence of Nature (a continuing and only lightly veiled theme in the natural sciences ever since).

¹⁵ Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan* (London: Penguin, 1985), 120.

many reasons for this, perhaps chief among them the shocking disaster of the "democratic" French Revolution, whose effects we are still feeling.¹⁶ That was the modern world's first political attempt to organize millions of people with the tools of rationalism, namely the secular concepts of mass administration and control, order, logic, mass conscription, equality, democracy, uniformity, obedience, and political correctness. At the high pitch of enthusiasm for all this, the Goddess of Reason had been erected in Notre Dame Cathedral in place of Jesus Christ and was worshipped by wine-imbibing, chanting devotees in white robes during special pagan ceremonies. In the same period a proposal was floated to remove all ancient names from French villages - because these carried historical nostalgia and replace them with numbers. Quaint thousand-year-old villages such as Saint Andre de Roquepertuis would now be called "village 67724." Fortunately, this idea died with Robespierre. But the practical results of the world's first social upheaval in the name of reason were nevertheless cataclysmic for the Western world. For after a brief honeymoon with the dream of a rationally designed secular utopia, the Revolution began devouring its own revolutionaries on the way to the slaughters of the Terror. This horrendous bloodbath - the French prophets of democracy hacking, chopping, guillotining, stabbing, and drowning thousands upon thousands of their own law-abiding citizens in a rationalist frenzy for equality - created, at least in Europe, what at first seemed a terminal loss of faith in the fruits of reason.

This made it easier for people to turn to darker levels of experience, and eventually to forms of extreme irrationality, for answers to what seemed the intractably depressing realities of human life. In the arts, things moved quickly from the prior rationalist art forms of the eighteenth century (sober, morally instructive poetry composed in measured rhyming couplets and the like) to the wilder, more emotionally spontaneous romantic forms of the next century (Wordsworth, Keats, Shelley, and Herder in poetry, Beethoven in music, etc.). With this came more violent revolution, social and industrial upheaval, a lot of aspiritual materialistic philosophies, communist class-warfare, existential angst, the depthless netherworld of psychoanalysis, and . . . the foundations for world war. By the end of the nineteenth century, the end of modernity, with its unquestioned faith in reason, was upon us - and we soon entered the long, badly named "postmodern" period. This meant a sudden end to the longstanding hope of discovering a universal human nature and a rational ethical foundation and the beginning of an even more energetic search - indeed, of a new hope that the truth might lie in things relative.

The Gentleman Relativists

We moderns were set up for this new embrace of relativism by influential gentleman philosophers such as John Locke (1632-1704) and David Hume (1711-1776). In striking contrast to his predecessors, so

¹⁶ I have argued elsewhere, especially in *Constitutional Crack-Up* (Toronto: Stoddart, 1994), that the French-style, top-down, code-law format of constitutional democracy has everywhere in the West been in conflict with a British-style, bottom-up, common-law parliamentary or congressional style. The former has everywhere imposed itself on the latter. Canada is an acute example of a country that existed for 115 years as a parliamentary democracy in the British fashion, in which members of the House responsible to the people made sovereign law (keeping in mind that until quite recently most parliamentarians believed in fixed and eternal laws of human nature that not even Parliament can alter). This was suddenly overturned by the more French constitutional method introduced by former prime minister Pierre Trudeau, in the form of a Charter of Rights and Freedoms, in 1982, which is now part of the Canadian Constitution and the "supreme" law (sec. 52) to of the Canadian Parliament and its statutes are subordinate. The effect this is that elected parliamentarians are now subservient to the opinions (which are not only legal but unavoidably also political, economic, and social) of unelected judges who must be asked to interpret the abstract words of the Charter. In a real sense, this has returned Canadians to the condition they were in prior to Confederation, at which time they won "responsible" government from British colonial rule. Prior to that, the governors of Canada were responsible to the British Parliament, not to the colonists they governed. In the same sense, Canadian parliamentarians may now be said to be more responsible to their judges than to their electors.

confident of our common sinful human nature, Locke argued that there are no innate or inherent (universal, absolute, constant) characteristics of our minds. A mind is like a school blackboard, a blank slate (*tabula rasa*) on which experience makes impressions.¹⁷ Accordingly, as they have no prior meaning in themselves, to know things means to understand the *relations* and *associations* between them.

The radical skeptic Hume went much further and argued that while knowledge indeed comes from sense experiences, as Locke had described, the relations between things, such as cause and effect, are based only on habit and other unwarranted assumptions. The sun comes up every day, so we are certain it will do the same tomorrow. But we have no proof it will. In both men we see the classical focus on the *essences* of things (Plato) or on the organic *substance* of things (Aristotle) replaced by a focus on the *relations* between them. Much contemporary thinking, even of the serious (as distinct from the stylish postmodern) type, whether in mathematics, philosophy or physics, is wholly submerged in this last mode of understanding reality and is expressed in such areas as chaos theory, spontaneous organization, emergentism, and field theory.¹⁸

Perhaps the most coolly influential modern philosopher to have pushed us toward all sorts of relativist conclusions, however, was the German Immanuel Kant (1724-1804). He opposed Locke's notion that the mind is a blank slate on the ground that the human mind has an innate (we would say a hardwired) capacity to generalize and categorize sense perceptions and form them into consistent, communicable ideas. The mind is not a blank slate, he argued, but rather more like an active agent, a kind of mental cookie cutter that of necessity shapes its own reality, and because of this, *there is no way to know what things in themselves, outside the mind, are really like*. Well, here was a serious formula that seemed to pave the way for the relativizing of all human reality, and this conclusion so disturbed Kant himself that he developed even more theories to establish universal and constant categories of thought and morality, without which, he maintained, human life would be unlivable. But the damage was done, and the prevalent modern idea is that we all live in Kant's prison house of personal perceptions.

Not long afterward came what amounted to a powerfully influential attack on the moral absolutism of the whole Judeo-Christian system by England's John Stuart Mill in his influential tract *On Liberty* (1859). Although a somewhat snobbish man, with high taste and firm personal expectations for moral behaviour and social "progress," Mill's work was extremely corrosive of Western moral and religious ideas as guides to behaviour. After he lost faith in his utilitarian ideal of "the greatest of the greatest number" as his "moral calculus" (during this period he described himself as "a thinking machine"), he turned to as a new moral standard to be limited only by his so-called "harm principle." This basically stated that we are free to do whatever as long as we do not harm others. It was an appealing but confused philosophy that enclosed each individual inside a private moral bubble of personal choices as if the opinions of society were of no real account. This led to confusions in Mill's theory, however, as anyone who bothers to read the whole tract will see, for a careful examination of *On Liberty* surprises us with the number of unresolved contradict claims. Despite this, his principle remains the most powerful and popular "moral" guideline cited by ordinary people in the West today, and its implicit command to "do your own thing, just don't harm me" *now quietly undergirds the philosophy of Western relativism* and, increasingly, the philosophy of Western courts. Indeed, no sharper indication of Mill's influence could be had than the decision of Canada's Supreme Court on 21 December 2005 in "*Swingers Clubs*" *R. v. Labaye*, which held that the ancient "community standards" test would henceforth be replaced by the principle of "harm." The

¹⁷ See especially Steven Pinker, *The Blank Slate: The Modern Denial of Human Nature* (New York: Viking Penguin, 2002).

¹⁸ Examples are Set Theory in mathematics, Field Theory in psychology, sociology, and physics, the attempt of Western philosophers to escape the particle problem of analytical thinking through phenomenology, and in general the modern interest in organic part-whole relationships, chaos theory, spontaneous organization, and "emergent properties" both in the natural world and in human fields such as economics.

court specifically referenced Mill as author of this principle. In this sense, it was Mill who almost single-handedly transformed the idea of liberty. Whereas the standard and brake on one's behaviour in the pursuit of liberty had originally been a regard for the good of all society - that is, for doing no harm to society, to the common good - liberty would now be completely self-regarding, its only brake the notion of harm to other individuals.

The Angry European Relativists

Meanwhile, during the nineteenth century there were many angry European relativists who rejected entirely, or sought to reshape as entirely, the whole Western tradition. Among them was Georg Hegel (1770-1831) who cleverly mixed determinism and things spiritual by speaking of history with a capital "H" as a force of nature that evolves with a mind of its own to ever higher levels. The unfortunate boost he gave to relativism was the idea that "History" is not something created with hard facts but an ever-evolving process that cannot be understood or evaluated at all except through the context of particular historical periods. In the end, he insisted, there is no God's-eye view of anything. Nothing stays the same in a universe that is ever-evolving toward its own perfect self-recognition. Now this may seem to be impenetrable German intellectual blather. But it unsettles anyone looking for a stable reality.

Another passionately defiant relativist was the Prussian thinker and romantic poet Johann Herder (1744-1803). He despised the subjection of European nations to the Enlightenment - mostly French - idea of a single universal human nature that is supposed to progress through a series of stages to an ideal rational state. This "filled him with anger." He believed, on the contrary, that "every tribe and people was unfathomably and indestructibly unique . . . Each nation represented a truth of its own, which was compounded of blood, soil, climate, environment, experience . . . *there was no universal criterion* by which to judge nations . . . Men did not create a nation; a nation brought forth men."¹⁹ In this sense, "he was a precursor of the moral and cultural relativism which was a prominent part of anthropology in the first part of the twentieth century and is still very much with us."²⁰ Indeed. Farther along in this book we will look at the ideological mischief of the relativism that sprang from Herder's concept of "the comity of nations as a garden of wildflowers," a concept derided by a contemporary anthropologist as "the most childish notion ever to have imposed itself on the credulity of an influential mind. Whatever he [Herder] may have imagined, the garden of human cultures contains just as many stink-lilies as violets, strangling vines as primrose, sick societies as those with rosy cheeks - and too many problems in the modern world come from sentimentally denying this fact."²¹

But it was Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900) who surely ranks as the most tormented and explicitly angry relativist. He lambasted Western traditions root and branch, particularly Christianity (although even he had a grudging admiration for Christ). The West, he cried, originally made a huge mistake falling for Plato's theory about absolutes that exist in some world of higher Ideals and perfect Forms. This was a terrible, life-denying concept that ruined Western civilization, mostly by producing Christianity, which he deeply disrespected as "a poor man's Platonism" because it substitutes a perfect dream-world heaven after death for the vale of tears in the here and now. He was adamant that such grotesquely false promises prevent us from ever fulfilling ourselves and concluded that as any religion is obviously a lie, there are no absolutes to guide us to admirable human action, only admirable human "Will." His key idea with respect to relativism was his well-known "there are no facts, only interpretations." Accordingly, he called leaders

¹⁹ J.L. Talmon, *Romanticism and Revolt* (New York: Norton, 1967), 100, my emphasis.

²⁰ Michael Krausz and Jack M. Meiland, eds, *Relativism, Cognitive and Moral* (Notre Dame, IL: University of Notre Dame Press, 1982), 7.

²¹ Roger Sandall, *The Culture Cult: Designer Tribalism and Other Essays* (New York: Westview Press, 2001), 107-8.

with strong charismatic personalities who could move us beyond our current deadening concepts of good and evil to create an entirely new world of original values.

The Practical American Relativists

Meanwhile, in America there were similar attacks on the idea of an absolute reality, especially of a moral reality. The philosopher William James (1842-1910) developed a philosophy called "pragmatism" asserting that ideas and actions regarding the good must be judged only in terms of their practical worldly consequences, for there is no higher external standard. "Man" is at the centre of things and must get along as best he can based on experience alone. His theory of reality was that whatever satisfies us is true, while whatever does not is false.

John Dewey (1859-1952), whose "child-centred" philosophy of education permeated North American schools for most of the twentieth century, felt much the same as James: man alone with his evolving experience is the measure of the evolving universe. There is no other truth. No final picture. Indeed, he fairly beseeched philosophers to stop searching for ultimate meanings, beginnings, final truths, and absolutes, for it makes no difference to human beings trapped inside their own experiences and perceptions whether some higher reality may exist, for this we can never know for certain. But we know enough to make sense of this world, to get along, and even to improve it. That should suffice.

Twentieth-Century Relativism

From this variety of influences the seedbed of modern relativism was well prepared by the start of the twentieth century. But it really picked up a head of steam about ten years after Einstein's Special Theory of Relativity appeared in 1905. Although only specialists to this day are able to understand this theory, the news of it at once produced "a vague source of unease," as British historian Paul Johnson puts it, such that after the physical and moral devastations of World War I, "the belief began to circulate, for the first time at a popular level, that there were no longer any absolutes: of time and space, of good and evil, of knowledge, and above all of value. Mistakenly but perhaps inevitably, relativity *became confused with relativism*." And, he adds, "no one was more distressed than Einstein by this public misapprehension." ²²

In Johnson's view, "the public response to [Einstein's theory] was one of the principal formative influences on the course of twentieth-century history. It formed a knife, inadvertently wielded by its author, to help cut society adrift from its traditional moorings in the faith and morals of Judeo-Christian culture." ²³ Johnson goes on to explain how this relativity-become-relativism worked its poison on the public mind through its various insidious combinations with Darwinism, Marxism, Freudianism, and a host of other "isms." And of course, most parents are by now all too familiar with the effects of relativism on moral behaviour in general and aware of its proliferation through systems of education, literature, and the arts.

Although Einstein's theories concern only the behaviour of matter at incomprehensible cosmic scales, energies, and speeds that have no direct effect on human life, the indirect idea that everything in the universe is relative seemed now to have the deepest scientific imprimatur. And just as society had for three centuries patterned its thinking after Newton's idea that the universe is a machine, it now began to pattern all thinking about science, morality, and culture as one or another form of unpredictable relativism. We were suddenly back at the uncertain and unknowable river of Heraclitus.

²² Paul Johnson, *Modern Times: The World from the Twenties to the Eighties* (New York: Harper and Row, 1983), 4, my emphasis.

²³ *Ibid.*, 5.

Alas, it is by now a certain fact (and Einstein had worried deeply this might come to be the case) that various between-the-wars ideologies such as fascism and communism rested on variations of a politically self-serving moral relativism that contributed to Europe's totalitarian nightmare. And even though the central legal foundation for the Western courts that condemned the Nazi machine at the postwar Nuremberg Trials was a form of moral and legal absolutism still called "natural law," this startling truth was easily lost in the general disillusion and the widespread repudiation of authority by the young. Just so, their attraction to existentialism was fuelled by their justifiable moral disappointment over two horrific world wars that displayed the full panoply of human cruelty and degradation. Existentialists argued that as there is obviously, if unfortunately, no God to create a human nature, or essence, of which we are all a manifestation, our existence must be only a brute fact of life and is basically senseless. It has no God-given meaning. We simply exist (hence, "existentialism") and so are abandoned in this world to carry on as free human agents carving out a moral universe according to our private personal choices, for there is no other arbiter of morality. For this reason, existentialists declared - in contrast to just about all prior philosophical and theological tradition - *our existence precedes our essence*.

By the 1970s, however, the disillusioned were no longer young. They were now wearing suits as professors and policy wonks in governments. And the trend was clear. With a mixture of philosophies drawn mostly from the thinkers reviewed here, they were energetically rejecting the old tenets of "modernism," which had taught that reason could reveal an objective world common to all. This belief was now characterized as a "Eurocentric" assumption, a philosophy invented by controlling intellectuals, by bureaucrats, or by the bourgeois-capitalist class (take your pick). Modern philosophy, we were now told - for that matter, all philosophies (take your pick again) - is just one story, or "narrative," that was invented by those striving for the dominance of their particular worldview and that reflects only their interests. Suddenly, it was fashionable to argue that the story about a stable world of objects and essences is false and part of a *controlling myth*. Here was a generation that preferred the idea that reality is unknowable *except as formed by each individual mind*, and as so much of thinking is expressed in language, this in turn produced the so-called "linguistic turn" in amateur philosophy: the idea that there is no reality except as created and perceived "the prison house of language." We will go into this more deeply in our later chapters on language. Suffice it to say for now that loosely speaking, the idea that everything is relative, invented, and therefore permeated with a controlling motive led at once to new forms of analytical suspicion directed at every aspect of human activity from poetry to politics. All social phenomena, in particular, would become targeted as explicit or implicit power structures justifying one or another form of moral, social, political, or economic control. So in rapid succession we got schools of structuralism, poststructuralism, deconstructionism, postmodernism, post-postmodernism, anti-foundationalism, and much more. With each phase we got a more and more stringent insistence on the essential sleaziness and political - which is self-serving - nature of all accepted forms of thinking, even the most professedly innocent. That is why we now live in an age of extreme skepticism and the almost total privatization of the idea of truth, which has taken cover within the isolated self.

What all these ideologies share is a reliance on the many variations of relativism - although many practical people have suspected that those professing such beliefs also share a need to maintain job security by creating unfalsifiable theories in otherwise exhausted fields of thought. At any rate, it is hard to say what will be next, But a reaction has been forming for some time because so many serious thinkers have by now grown very tired of misleading and self-refuting claims that there is nothing of value to know or to teach because nothing is true, fixed, or stable. Recently, Renato Rosaldo, a professor of anthropology at Stanford University, went public with the opinion that today, "in academic debate, calling someone a

relativist is a mild form of verbal abuse."²⁴ That is certainly new and indicative not only of a philosophical rift in his field of study but also of the hunger being felt once again for what is known, what can be known, and above all for what is common, universal, constant, or absolute.

To summarize, we began by outlining a key distinction between relationism and relativism and then proceeded to a brief history of relativism in Western civilization. After its first appearance in the ancient world, soon to be demolished by the powerfully persuasive logical force of both Platonic and Aristotelian philosophy, relativism did not arise again in a serious way until the Renaissance. At this point, after the philosophical and theological exhaustions of the Middle Ages, we begin to see the waning of public faith in religious and moral authority. This was soon combined with the Reformation's insistence on the spark of inner truth as something available to all, with the powerful effects of rationalism, and with the objective discoveries of science. The result was that the findings of reason and science began to embarrass religious authority. The new concept of the cosmos as a Newtonian machine running according to its own fixed laws of which the earth was but a lonely part began to replace the old earth-centred idea that the cosmos has a purpose to which human existence is central. This new objectivism soon led to more skepticism and doubt and therefore to a general subjectivism in morals. It was not a great step from this subjectivism to the birth of modern relativism. There were many genteel thinkers who used very sophisticated arguments to hone the relativist view of human knowledge and perception. By the nineteenth century, however, we begin to see a more angry and defiant repudiation of the old belief that reason would or could lead us to the truth. There were also a lot of calm but persistent theories in America and England about the relativism of human knowledge and therefore of the difficulty in establishing moral standards. Mill, above all, reduced the idea of morality to a vague subjective ideal. The result was that by the early twentieth century, relativism had become our new public orthodoxy, and Einstein's theory of relativity, for all the wrong reasons, as we shall see, seemed to give it a foundation in physical reality. The ensuing postwar intellectual movements can be said to have only further entrenched the modern relativist revival, each in its own way, such that relativist orthodoxy in many shapes and forms is more or less pervasive in almost all educational and intellectual departments, disciplines, and spheres of influence.

Against the Grain

This is so despite the existence of a sizable community of thinkers, researchers, and scientists from a wide variety of fields who have refused to follow the relativist trend for the reason that they find it both logically incoherent and falsified by actual experience. They also know that the professional fields in which they work would simply not exist but for the presence of a great number of absolutes, constants, and universals of the kind it will be our pleasure to explore in the rest of this book.

Many of these imposing thinkers, from Plato and Aristotle to modern critics of relativism such as Einstein himself, Sir Roger Penrose, and just about every serious philosopher, have put relativism in the stand and examined it thoroughly to see whether it could stand up to scrutiny, only to conclude it is a seriously flawed worldview.

Despite this, relativism remains a public force. It is a radical philosophical and moral claim that tends toward the indeterminate and the mystical and that gives satisfaction to believers by undermining any absolute truths, universals, and certainties they dislike and find uncomfortable. Due to its current omnipresence, however, it deserves to be taken seriously and examined on its own merits. For in the end,

²⁴ Renato Rosaldo, "Of Headhunters and Soldiers: Separating Cultural and Ethical Relativism," conference paper, www.scu.edu/ethics/publications/iie/v11n1/relativism.html.

each of us must decide if relativism should be embraced as a satisfying and complete public philosophy or be dropped once again into the dustbin of historical triviality.

What follows next is a brief survey of the main types of relativism, followed by a chapter giving some of the reasons why so many important thinkers in history have concluded that relativism richly deserves the latter fate. In none of this do I bother to defend relativism, for the reason that it needs no defence. It is already almost everywhere believed, defended, and promoted, however unsubtly. What it has needed, rather, is a well-rounded expose and critique, of which there are very few to be found, and this I hope the reader, after reading what follows, will agree I have supplied.

Only the Lover Sings

Joseph Pieper

Work, Spare Time, and Leisure

*This talk was the keynote address at the opening of an art exhibition
in conjunction with the Ruhrfestspiele (1953).*

First published in Die Zeit, June 25, 1953.

THESE THREE CONCEPTS, at first sight, do not give any indication that they hide a deeply challenging problem, and no mere theoretical problem either. No, they rather give the impression of being entirely innocuous; they could easily be understood, approvingly or with reservations, as an invitation "to take it easy". Our title seems to project an uncomplicated, even cheerful, serenity, progressing from one concept to the next. "Work", it is true, may still be part of life's burden, but it is already alleviated and forgotten as it leads to "spare time" and finally to "leisure", with its vision of the solitary fisherman who in utter contentment sits on a summer lakeshore, less intent on catching a fish than simply on relaxing and daydreaming. Where, pray, should the problem be lurking?

The term and concept of "work" are entirely familiar to us. Work is that which gives man's workday its name; it satisfies our basic needs and procures our daily bread; it constitutes the active effort to provide those things indispensable in order to stay alive. Nothing is more obvious.

And why should the meaning of "spare time" not be equally obvious? Spare time is a multi-layered concept. As long as it is defined *negatively*, as a span of time *not* filled with work, no problem arises. Similarly, if we consider the concept of spare time only in its relationship to the concept of "workday", if we define spare time as a mere break from work in order to recover, a time after work to restore one's strength for more work, then again, no particular problem will arise.

But some second thought might stir us up as soon as we consider that we do not really succeed in defining spare time only in this way. A moment ago I used, in all innocence, the term "workday". The notion of workday immediately evokes one other notion, closely related, which provides a rather fresh and now positive definition of spare time—a definition indicating that here we are discussing something beyond a mere break in working time or a pause to gather new strength. This other notion is "holiday". On the one hand, we have not succeeded—rather: not yet!—in eliminating the notion of holiday from our thinking (which shows the persistence of Western tradition.) On the other hand, this notion of holiday has generally lost for us its clarity, depth, and unquestioned inner meaning (which indicates how weakened and threatened our Western standards have become). A holiday, a feast day—what is this, anyway, and what in essence does it mean?

How does the spirit of celebration originate in the heart of man, how can it be fostered and preserved? And how can we possibly observe a feast day on a truly existential level without such a spirit of celebration? I very much fear that the typical modern man may no longer be able to draw answers to these questions from immediate awareness and inner experience. Of course, we still have some vague notion that the seventh day of the week is not simply the "weekend" but has a deeper significance. We still are receptive to the reminder implied in that uniquely German term *Feierabend* [meaning, "quitting time," but literally, "evening for celebration"—the reminder that more is meant here than a mere break to catch one's breath. And we still have not entirely forgotten that the German word *Ferien* (vacation time) literally means "festive time." All of which, taken together, means one thing: the concept of spare time is by no means so simple and innocu-

ous as at first it may have appeared. It springs from some profound dimension where it merges, lacking precise bounds, with the third concept, that of "leisure."

About this concept we confidently dare to affirm that we do not know what it means. More to the point: we are ignorant of how the concept of "leisure" is understood in the accumulated wisdom of our Western cultural and existential tradition as expressed, say, by Plato, Aristotle, or the great teachers of Christianity. Granted, one could say: but why *should* we know that? What difference does this particular ignorance make? The way we see the human person and therefore the meaning of our existence has, after all, changed considerably since the time of antiquity and the Middle Ages!

Such an objection must not be taken lightly. At any rate, however, even should we agree with it (and then especially), we have to realize what in truth this discussion is all about. We must understand that a total and final disintegration of the concept of "leisure", a basic concept of traditional Western thinking, will have a clear historical consequence; namely, the totalitarian work state. If we dislike this consequence, we must understand that there can be only one valid objection against the idolizing of labor, an objection based on some ultimate truth about human nature and therefore of sole and lasting relevance. To identify such an objection, we must discover anew, and appropriate again, the meaning of the statement, "We work so we can have leisure."

What indeed is declared here? A veritable thicket of misconceptions must be cleared away before the true meaning of this statement can appear. For this purpose, it is indispensable to spell out certain simple basics. It seems the German language is no help in this, since *Musse* (leisure) and *Müssiggang* (loafing) distressingly are such close neighbors, though in terminology only. Looking at the factual content, "loafing" is the exact opposite of "engaging in leisure" (as the ancient Greeks put it, *scholén agein*). "We work so we can have leisure", would therefore, as a preliminary approach, declare this: we work in order to do—to enable us to do—something other than work. What is this "something other"? Recreation, entertainment, amusement, play—all this is *not* meant here. Wouldn't it be quite nonsensical to think of work as drawing its justification from play? No, this "something other" indicates an activity meaningful in itself. But is not work equally meaningful? Meaningful indeed! Yet not meaningful in itself. This precisely defines the concept of work: it has a practical purpose, it produces utilitarian goods, it contributes to the common useful wealth (and "useful" always means "good for something else"). To serve some other purpose is the essential characteristic of work. In this context also belongs the old and rather offensive expression, "servile work". The terms alone do not at all imply any contempt for work, much less for the worker. We can say the opposite is true.

But then, traditional wisdom has always understood that there are also human activities that do not serve some other purpose and so are not servile. These are forms of activities to which everybody, including the working man, is entitled, even as a fundamental right and necessity (in the same way as the servile activity, namely work, which satisfies basic needs and serves a practical purpose, is as a rule required of everybody).

At this point it seems advisable to mention the old distinction—some would say, the old-fashioned and only historically relevant distinction between "servile arts" and "liberal arts", *artes serviles* and *artes liberales*. This distinction, in fact, is anything but old-fashioned; it can claim a contemporary political relevance. Translated into the jargon of a world defined by work alone, it says: not only do production quotas and the implementation of planning goals exist, but in addition and by right, there are human activities that by their very nature lie beyond the standards of any five-year plan. This means that there are human actions that need not be justified by a society's yardstick of economical usefulness, and absolutely so. All we have to do is use such terms to bring out the

radical challenge to the domain of absolute work. This challenge is contained in the traditional Western tenet: there do exist "liberal arts", there do exist human activities that are meaningful without being either work or mere respite (from work, for more work). This too, I hope, has become clear: it is an insidiously dangerous and consequential undertaking to deny that work is characterized by its "usefulness-for-something-else", even—yes!—by its "servile" dimension. It is a fiction to declare work, the production of useful things, to be meaningful in itself. Such fiction leads to the exact opposite of what it seems to accomplish. It brings about the exact opposite of "liberation", "elevation", or "rehabilitation" for the worker. It brings about precisely that inhuman dimension so typical of the world of absolute work: it accomplishes the final bondage of man within the process of work, it explicitly makes everybody a proletarian. This is happening openly and explicitly in those totalitarian "Workers' States", but it is also infecting all other parts of the world, at least as a danger and temptation. It shows, for instance, in the difficulty we experience in answering this question: of what, then, might such activity "meaningful in itself", such "liberal" activity, consist? How should we conceive of such an activity that does not need something other for its justification that is not defined as producing useful goods and objective results? An activity that does not bring forth the means for our existence but is existential realization itself, an activity in which man's true and proper good, his genuine richness, fullest life, and most perfect happiness is attained?

Obviously, an answer here is possible only if a specific concept of the human person is accepted. For nothing less is at stake here than the ultimate fulfillment of human existence. We are really asking how such fulfillment may come about. Originality, or the lack of it, seems to me quite irrelevant in this regard. I am only trying to express the teaching found in the Western philosophical tradition. The most important element in this teaching declares: the ultimate fulfillment, the absolutely meaningful activity, the most perfect expression of being alive, the deepest satisfaction, and the fullest achievement of human existence must needs happen in an instance of beholding, namely in the contemplating awareness of the world's ultimate and intrinsic foundations. Thus would Plato express the sum total of his insights:

Here, if anywhere at all—so spoke the foreign maiden from Mantinea (Diotima)—here man's life becomes fully worth living; for here he beholds the divine revealed in the purity of beauty itself: through this he becomes immortal.

A rather small step will bring us back again to the realm of concrete things. The reader may already have wondered, with some misgivings or even dismay, how many more abstruse philosophical subtleties he must endure. Fear not; we have returned to our entirely practical question: What constitutes, here and now, an activity meaningful in itself? I have stated it before: if we are unable to answer this question, then we will also be unable to resist convincingly the claims of a world absolutely defined by work. The answer contained in our Western philosophical tradition could be summed up in this way. Whenever in reflective and receptive contemplation we touch, even remotely, the core of all things, the hidden, ultimate reason of the living universe, the divine foundation of all that is, the purest form of all archetypes (and the act of perception, immersed in contemplation, is the most intensive form of grasping and owning), whenever and wherever we thus behold the very essence of reality—there is an activity that is meaningful in itself taking place.

Such reaching out in contemplation to the root and foundation of all that is, to the archetypes of all things, this activity that is meaningful in itself can happen in countless actual forms. A particularly venerable form, particularly neglected as well, is religious meditation, the contemplative immersion

of the self into the divine mysteries. Another form is philosophical reflection, which should indeed not be conceived as limited to some specialized academic discipline. Anybody can ponder human deeds and happenings and thus gaze into the unfathomable depths of destiny and history; anybody can get absorbed in the contemplation of a rose or human face and thus touch the mystery of creation; everybody, therefore, participates in the quest that has stirred the minds of the great philosophers since the beginning. We see still another form of such activity in the creation of the artist, who does not so much aim at presenting copies of reality as rather making visible and tangible in speech, sound, color, and stone, the archetypal essences of all things as he was privileged to perceive them. But those, too, who experience the spark of poetry while listening to a poem, who behold a sculpture and perceive the artist's intention—yes, those who only listen and observe, as long as the conditions are right, can also touch, in contemplation, the core of all reality, the domain of the eternal archetypes. "If the conditions are right"—here lies the difficulty. It is specifically the difficulty already mentioned: to be aware of those different forms of touching the core of reality and to acknowledge them as "meaningful in themselves", to experience them and simply to live them as such. Could it be that this difficulty represents the deeper reason for the increasing isolation today surrounding artists and poets, but also philosophers and certainly those dedicated to the contemplative life?

We ought to mention here certain conditions and premises intimately tied, it seems, to the activity that is meaningful in itself. Not much more than a brief enumeration is possible, though. An activity which is meaningful in itself, first, cannot be accomplished except with an attitude of receptive openness and attentive silence—which, indeed, is the exact opposite of the worker's attitude marked by concentrated exertion. One of the fundamental human experiences is the realization that the truly great and uplifting things in life come about perhaps not without our own efforts but nevertheless not through those efforts. Rather, we will obtain them only if we can accept them as free gifts.

With this, we touch on a second precondition, even more fundamental than the first and more removed from any willful manipulation. If this other condition is not fulfilled, we cannot expect to accomplish any action meaningful in itself. Rather, we cannot expect that the meditative perception of the world's foundations will be experienced as meaningful in itself, whether it happens in the form of poetry, music, the fine arts, philosophy, or religious contemplation. This second condition, in a nutshell, is this: the ability to celebrate a feast. What, then, is required to celebrate a feast? Obviously more than a day off from work. This requirement includes man's willing acceptance of the ultimate truth, in spite of the world's riddles, even when this truth is beheld through the veil of our own tears; it includes man's awareness of being in harmony with these fundamental realities and surrounded by them. To express such acceptance, such harmony, such unity in non-ordinary ways—this has been called since time immemorial: to celebrate a feast. And at this point we realize that there can be no feast without gods; indeed, that the cultic celebration is the primordial form of any feast. This, however, is a different topic. And yet, this much shall be stated here: only such a fundamental attitude of acceptance can create, within the flow of workdays, the liberal breathing space that allows us, oblivious of life's more basic necessities, to do what is meaningful in itself. It is for this reason, on the other hand, that all forms of "liberal" activities, above all in the area of the arts, are essentially of a festive nature as long as they contain at least some remote echo of that fundamental attitude of acceptance. Wherever this attitude becomes entirely defunct, there all endeavors to organize "relaxation" surely turn into an even more hectic, indeed an outright desperate, form of work. This is not such a farfetched notion and hardly requires concrete proof. And one further aspect, I think, is not foreign to our personal experience. It is artistic activity especially

that can degenerate—either into idle and empty game playing or into some novel and sophisticated form of busy-ness, profiteering, and nervous distraction—if it does not simply sink to the level of crass entertainment apt to seduce man to make himself a prisoner of his workdays with no thought of escaping.

Wherever the arts are nourished through the festive contemplation of universal realities and their sustaining reasons, there in truth something like a liberation occurs: the stepping-out into the open under an endless sky, not only for the creative artist himself but for the beholder as well, even the most humble. Such liberation, such foreshadowing of the ultimate and perfect fulfillment, is necessary for man, almost more necessary than his daily bread, which is indeed indispensable and yet insufficient.

In this precisely do I see the meaning of that statement in Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics*, "We work so we can have leisure".

Population and the Wealth of Nations

William McGurn

By any measure, the future for this Asian country looked bleak. Enormously overcrowded, its normal population had skyrocketed, increased not just by a naturally high birthrate but also by revolution in a neighboring country - forcing thousands of desperate refugees upon its borders. Lacking natural resources and utterly dependent upon its unpleasant neighbor for water and food, the country's situation had deteriorated so badly that a local UN official declared the only way for it to survive would be with massive Western aid. An American newspaper proclaimed the country to be "dying," and the government itself inclined to despair. Its own annual report painted a graphic picture:

Virtually every sizable vacant site . . . was occupied, and when there was no flat land remaining, [people] moved up to the hillsides and colonized the ravines and slopes which were too steep for normal development. The huts were constructed of such material as they could lay hands on at little or no cost - flattened sheets of tin, wooden boarding, cardboard, sacking slung on frames. . . Land was scarce even for the squatters and the huts were packed like dense honeycombs or irregular warrens at different levels, with little ventilation and no regular access. The shacks themselves were crowded beyond endurance. . . Density was at a rate of two thousand persons to an acre in single-story huts. There was, of course, no sanitation.

"The problem of a rapidly increasing population," the government lamented, "lies at the core of every problem facing the administration."

These words might describe dozens of countries around the world today. In fact, they were written in the 1950s about Hong Kong - the same British colony that today has become a synonym for dynamism and development, with a per capita gross domestic product eclipsing Mother England's. Indeed, at the very moment these government reports were being written, Hong Kong was on the cusp of a general Asian economic boom that would see real income per capita in Japan and the Four Tigers (Hong Kong, Singapore, Taiwan, and South Korea) quadruple from 1960 to 1985. Though many observers felt as the American journalist John Robbins did in 1959, when he asserted that "Hong Kong's state of supersaturation" may be "a portent of things to come throughout Asia," the apocalypse they predicted never came to pass. Instead, Hong Kong witnessed the greatest economic boom of its history, and now boasts a population of more than six million people - about five times the number the Hong Kong government in 1954 declared to be its carrying "capacity."

Though there are parts of Hong Kong that rank among the most densely packed areas in the world, it remains a peaceable and safe city - a fact not unrelated to the tangible sense of opportunity granted by its (presently) open economic system. The lesson Hong Kong teaches is that there is no fixed level of resources, no natural capacity, no predefined limit to what people might do if given the opportunity to exercise the real factors in development: enterprise, creativity, and risk.

For the Catholic Church in particular, Hong Kong stands as a sharp rebuke to the reigning zero sum ethos of the day, and brings us back to the core of Catholic social teaching: the value of human life not only to its possessors but to their neighbors as well. In the dismal abacus of our day, when a pig is born in China, national wealth goes up; when a child is born, it goes down.

Almost all the fervor for population control traces back to this premise, which reflects a theological confusion as much as an economic one, and it derives from the historical tendency of Western experts to see Asian peoples as mouths and not minds.

When the push for reducing population growth began in the 1950s and 1960s, it owed much to this reduction of the human being to a collection of animal appetites and urges. The philosophical father to this school of thought is, of course, Thomas Malthus, who argued in his *Essay on the Principle of Population* (1798) that "the perpetual tendency in the race of man to increase beyond the means of subsistence is one of the great general laws of animated nature which we can have no reason to expect will change." The catastrophes Malthus predicted never came to pass, but his brand of pessimism nonetheless continues.

In 1968 Paul Ehrlich opened his seminal work *The Population Bomb* with the declaration that "the battle to feed all of humanity is over. In the 1970s the world will undergo famines - hundreds of millions of people are going to starve to death." In 1977 Robert McNamara, as head of the World Bank, saw in population growth the "gravest issue" short of nuclear war and in a particularly prophetic statement lamented that the decisions that had led to this growth were "not in the exclusive control of a few governments but rather in the literally hundreds of millions of individual parents who will determine the outcome." Back in the 1950s William Vogt, in his best-selling book, *Road to Survival*, attributed Asia's population growth to "untrammelled copulation" by "the backward billion," while A. J. Carlson warned in a 1955 article in the *Journal of the American Medical Association* that "if we breed like rabbits, in the long run we have to live and die like rabbits." Everywhere the distaste for human beings was on display - joined to the notion that the poorer parts of the world were dragging down richer.

"It is easy to imagine the United States or Canada or Brazil, or even - with somewhat more effort - France supporting twice its 1960 population on a reasonably decent standard of living," observed John Robbins in his 1959 book, *Too Many Asians*. But how, he asked, "can twice as many Asians hope to live on even today's miserable scale?" As it turned out, of course, Asia more than doubled in size and set off a new industrial revolution whose impact on human welfare has been of revolutionary proportions by virtually any measure: infant mortality, literacy, life expectancy, caloric intake, etc. The Indian economist Amartya Sen notes, moreover, that the growth in per capita income has been about one-third greater in countries at the bottom of the economic heap than those at the high end, and that the figures would be even higher if sub-Saharan Africa were excluded.

There is no way to deny this achievement. In his recent book *Asia Rising*, the economist Jim Rohwer points out that from 1970 to 1990 the number of desperately poor East Asians fell from 400 million to 180 million, even while the population of those countries was rising by 425 million - in other words, East Asia achieved a net rescue from poverty of almost 650 million people. It was done, moreover Shimura, the Japanese, in places with few natural resources and against all expectations.

A few observers did foresee this at the time. Amid all the headlines predicting famine and chaos, there appears an astounding paragraph written in a 1957 by Isamu managing director of Toyo Menka Kaisha. Inverting the usual way of looking at population and economics, he showed himself far more astute than many experts when he wrote:

Instead of thinking our population is too large for our economy; I believe it is more correct to say the scale of our economy is too small for our population. Instead of surplus, unwanted persons, we should view our people as our most valuable natural resource. This is not only the humane but the realistic view. The Japanese people are hard working, energetic and resourceful, with a high level of education, skills, and competence. We are at the beginning of revolutionary industrial changes among which the recent achievements in synthetic chemistry and the potentialities in the peaceful use of atomic energy are mere portents. These new discoveries indicate clearly that in the economy of the future, whose beginnings are already among us, the economic resources which count will not be natural ones but human-intelligence, skill, and foresight.

It was an extraordinary insight at the time (Shimura also predicted that Japan would become a major producer of cars), and it remains telling today as we move toward a globalized economy.

And the thoughts it voices about the relationship between people and wealth are equally applicable to modern China and Indonesia. Not only has China's embrace of the market ended food shortages, but - in booming Canton - the experiment with markets has been so successful that the province has had to import some ten million Chinese workers from other provinces. Indonesia started to throw off the shackles of socialism in the mid-1960s when President Suharto assumed power, and the result has been one of the fastest sustained economic growth rates in the world.

To be sure, East Asia's revolution is not much different from that which the Western world experienced two hundred years before. Since the middle of the eighteenth century, the West's population has more than quadrupled while real income per head increased at least fivefold - an even faster rate than today's population growth in the Third World.

This is not to say that population control has made no headway in Asia. Pushed incessantly by figures like the World Bank's McNamara, the idea that nations could become rich only if they moved to control their population rates became an article of faith among Western and Western educated intellectuals in Asia - a faith backed up by aid dollars linked to the willingness of recipient countries to develop control measures. In the Philippines, for example, the U.S. Agency for International Development obtained a provision in the Marcos-era constitution granting the state authority over population levels. The Western missionary fervor once directed at Christianizing Asia has been channeled, in the second half of the twentieth century, into proselytizing for fewer Asians.

Despite its notable failures, moreover, population control has become orthodoxy in a number of states, especially China. Through the 1950s, Maoist doctrine held large populations to be assets, with increased size corresponding to increased output. In this Mao was right, as the subsequent development of its neighbors demonstrates. Where Chinese communism erred was not in its estimation of the Chinese but in its estimation of communism.

This is not the place to discuss the well-documented horrors of population control in Asia: the forced abortions, sterilizations, and even infanticides. I want to suggest, however, that these horrors are a direct consequence of the idea that development requires poor nations to limit their populations - which also explains, I believe, the pronounced indifference in the West to practices that would provoke outrage were they applied to people in Scarsdale or San Francisco instead of Shanghai and Bombay. Without the economic imperative underlying population control, the abuses have no rational motivation. And so long as that dismal imperative is accepted, reservations (such as those expressed so eloquently by Pope John Paul II) are dismissed as a luxury the world literally cannot afford.

It is worth noting that two to three decades of sustained pressure for the suppression of population growth is beginning to have consequences unforeseen by its advocates. Most of the freer Asian countries at one time or another adopted policies penalizing large families or offering incentives to small families, whether through the tax code or through benefits like preferential housing and jobs. And over the years most of these nations have succeeded in lowering their total fertility rates. From 1953 to 1993, the annual number of births per thousand people in Taiwan dropped from forty-five to sixteen and the average number of children in a Taiwanese family dropped from seven to 1.7 (below the number for the U.S., Britain, and even China). With increased average life spans, it means a grayer and grayer Taiwan: In 1994 people over sixty-five years old accounted for only 7 percent of the population; by 2036 the figure will be three times as large - which means a smaller percentage of workers. In response to such trends, Singapore has already shifted from promoting smaller families to promoting larger ones. It is in China, however, where population control has been stringent, that two nasty side effects appear most clearly: the world's most rapidly aging society and a dangerously skewed ratio between boys and girls.

The demographic shifts are obvious to the most casual visitor. In the Temple of Heaven Park in Beijing, there are legions of adults for each child. The Chinese press regularly reports on the "little emperors," the army of spoilt only-children used to getting their own way. And these children are the same people who as adults will be called upon to make enormous sacrifices to support China's growing ranks of the elderly - for not only is China graying, it is doing it faster than any population in history. A process that took eighty-five years in Sweden and thirty-two years in Japan will take only twenty-one years in China, according to the Beijing Center of Gerontology. China already has the largest number of elderly in the world, and the projections of the number of workers compared to the number of retirees are stark. The Chinese Statistics Bureau reports that in 1987 the people over sixty years were 13.5 percent. As the effects of the one-child program make themselves felt, however, the numbers leap dramatically: to 23.8 percent in 2020, 36 percent in 2030, and 44.9 percent in 2050 - when more than 400 million Chinese will be over sixty years of age, and there will be almost one retiree for every two workers. The Japanese are already paying higher taxes imposed by leaders worried about their own graying society. But Japan's problems pale beside China's, which is nowhere near as wealthy, about ten times more populous, and aging at a much faster clip.

The practice of sex selection creates related problems. Within Asia generally, there exists a strong cultural preference for sons, based on the not irrational idea that sons support their parents in old age and carry on the family name. In China the combination of this bias in favor of sons and the one-child policy has in practice meant the aborting of many fetuses simply because they are girls. The result is that whereas the normal relationship is 104 to 107 boys for every 100 girls born, China now sees 119 boys born for every 100 girls. (Other Asian countries have corresponding figures: 114 in South Korea, 110 in Taiwan, and as many as 112 in India.) This shift too will begin to make itself felt when whole generations of boys suddenly find themselves unable to find wives, with harrowing ramifications for social order.

If the 1995 UN Conference on Population in Cairo demonstrated anything, it is that the Catholic Church remains the chief stumbling block to the true believers in population control. Yet even the Church at times does not seem to realize the strength of its own teaching - its conformity with laws of economics as well as nature and its congruence with what we can now see is the real path to development and opportunity. Unfortunately too the Church can show a keener appreciation of its enemies than its friends, and it needs to express more clearly the fundamental unity of its teachings for individuals and its teachings for societies.

This unity is commonly understood in most areas of Church teaching: Traditional morality has always asserted that both the individuals themselves and society in general will be better off if individuals don't steal, don't cheat, and so on down the line. But when it comes to reproduction, the understanding seems to disappear. As a matter of living responsibly, a good case might be made for the bare assertion "no abortion or birth control and damn the consequences." But the Church has faltered in explaining the link between our reproductive behavior as individuals and the health of society. This is why Church leaders who concede the problem of overpopulation find themselves in the losing position of acknowledging a problem for which they must then rule out the obvious solution. Not surprisingly, their position looks arbitrary and unintelligible. And in the West, at least, the result is considerable media pressure for the Church to change its teaching and an expectation that it will once it faces up to the evidence.

In the case of population, the irony is that no serious market economist accepts the problem as defined, much less the proposed solutions. Whatever their personal views on abortion or birth control as an individual preference; neither Milton Friedman nor Gary Becker argue that societies need to curb population growth for development. The free-market the orientation of economists, the more they recognize that in an open economy individuals produce more than they consume. (It is no coincidence that those thumping the loudest for a state role in controlling population promote a bigger state role in lots of

other things as well: A "Catholics Speak Out" advertisement that appeared just before the Cairo conference called upon the Church's "male celibate hierarchy" to revise its teachings on sex, and in the very next sentence described the need to "redistribute" resources.)

Even John Paul II complicates matters for himself when he concedes "grave and serious problems" caused by overpopulation but then encourages people to have as many children as they see fit given their circumstances. Yet the lines are being drawn. For the real and sustained opposition to Church teaching today is, as the Pope indicated in his encyclical *Evangelium Vitae*, an ascendant "culture of death" that has turned legitimate concerns (such as the state of the environment) into frankly pagan movements. When these movements find themselves opposed to Rome, as they did so dramatically in recent UN conferences, it is not because they are illogical, but because they are simply following their assumptions to their inevitable conclusions. At its core the argument today is not over how many people a given country should have, or even whether abortion and birth control should be legal. At the core, the real argument has to do with the nature of man. Well before it was popular, Gunnar Myrdal realized that "the population question" held out the potential to become "the most effective argument for a thorough and radical socialist remodeling of society." Today the tactical arguments of this crowd have wisely shifted away from control toward "choice," "public health," and "empowerment," but the impetus remains the same.

In my own profession of journalism it is common enough to deride economists as practitioners of the "dismal science." Yet in most cases it is the economists who have maintained faith in human ingenuity and initiative and who have rejected counsels of despair and control. The majority of them have never been found on the front lines of the movement for population control. And the reason is that the best economists spend their lives emphasizing that economic life is not about numbers, but about the triumph of the human mind when given the freedom to innovate and respond. It is the market economist who argues for hope, who points to creativity when others push for control, who recognizes that people are good, in a fundamental, real sense: assets, not liabilities.

It was this human capital that took a desperate refugee population in Hong Kong and turned it into a world-class financial center; this human capital that saw Japan and South Korea arise from the ashes of war; this human capital whose success in turning around centuries of poverty has led to what the World Bank calls "The East Asian Miracle." And it is this philosophy of freedom that offers an answer, really the only answer, to the challenge posed to us by what John Paul II has so presciently recognized as a culture of death. Certainly in a world where many still go hungry at night there is much to be done. But instead of looking for ways to reduce the number of those seeking to take their place at the table, we should look for ways to eliminate the perverse policies that prevent a bigger banquet. And here Adam Smith will prove a more gracious host than Thomas Malthus.